



Waves of missiles eliminate air defenses and military sites

Trump calls on Iranian civilians to ‘take over’ once the attacks end

IRGC commander among raft of top leaders ‘eliminated,’ IDF says

Khamenei dead in U.S.-Israel attack to topple Iran’s regime

TRUMP: NO LETUP UNTIL MISSION DONE

‘Freedom for the people’ is goal, president says

BY NATALIE ALLISON AND TARA COPP

President Donald Trump told The Washington Post on Saturday that his main concern is “freedom” for the Iranian people as the U.S. launched military strikes in the country in a bold daytime attack that struck hundreds of missile and air defense sites and eliminated layers of leadership in the Iranian regime, most significant among them the country’s longtime supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

“Khamenei, one of the most evil people in History, is dead,” Trump posted to Truth Social. “This is not only Justice for the people of Iran, but for all Great Americans.”

“This is the single greatest chance for the Iranian people to take back their country,” Trump added.

The multiday operation against Iran began around 1 a.m. Eastern time with a salvo of ship-launched Tomahawk cruise missiles and air-launched munitions from U.S. Air Force and Navy jets, after repeated warnings by Trump of a possible attack in response to Iran’s nuclear program. The strikes are expected to last at least through the weekend, a U.S. official said.

The Pentagon has so far disclosed very little about the operation — called Epic Fury — and the

SEE IRAN ON A10



ABBAS ZAKERI/MEHR NEWS/WANA/REUTERS

AYATOLLAH ALI KHAMENEI | 1939 - 2026

Supreme leader wielded ultimate political, religious authority

BY WILLIAM BRANIGIN

Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the Shiite Muslim cleric who played a behind-the-scenes role in Iran’s Islamic revolution, served two terms as president in the 1980s and dominated the country for more than three decades as supreme leader, was killed Saturday as Israel and the United States launched a joint attack on Iran. He was 86.



Khamenei

President Donald Trump announced the death in a Truth Social post, calling the ayatollah “one of the most evil people in History.” He did not share additional details, but four Israeli security officials said Ayatollah Khamenei was killed in an Israeli airstrike at his compound in Tehran.

The strike came near the outset of a joint attack aimed at decimating Iran’s nuclear program and military and fueling a change in government. Black smoke billowed over the compound Saturday, although it was not immediately clear whether the supreme leader was there at the time. The strikes were aimed at top military and civilian leaders, including the ayatollah, Israeli sources said.

In announcing the attack, the second by Israeli and U.S. forces since June 2025, Trump publicly urged Iranians to “take over your government” once the operation ended. He had previously called on Iranians to rise up and pledged U.S. backing after widespread an-

SEE KHAMENEI ON A12



REUTERS

FROM TOP: Rescuers on Saturday at a school in Minab, Iran, where Iran’s foreign minister said dozens of children were killed. A satellite image shows damage from Ayatollah Ali Khamenei’s compound in Tehran following the airstrikes that killed him.

Push from Saudis, Israel helped move Trump to attack Iran

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM, JOHN HUDSON, KAREN DEYOUNG AND NATALIE ALLISON

President Donald Trump launched Saturday’s wide-ranging attack on Iran after a weeks-long lobbying effort by an unusual pair of U.S. allies in the Middle East: Israel and Saudi Arabia, according to four people familiar with the matter, as Israeli and U.S. forces teamed to topple Iranian Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei after nearly four decades in power.

Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman made multiple private phone calls to Trump over the past month advocating a U.S. attack, despite his public support for a diplomatic solution, the four people said. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, meantime, continued his long-running

public campaign for U.S. strikes against what he views as an existential enemy of his country.

The combined effort helped lead Trump to order a massive aerial campaign against Iran’s leadership and military, which in its initial hour led to the death of Khamenei and several other senior Iranian officials.

The attack came despite U.S. intelligence assessments that Iran’s forces were unlikely to pose an immediate threat to the U.S. mainland within the next decade. Saturday’s attack on Iran was a break from decades of U.S. decision-making to hold back from a full-scale effort to depose the regime of a country of more than 90 million people. It also marked a stark shift from Trump’s own previous military forays, which until now have been far narrower in scope.

SEE TRUMP ON A11

Most Americans say they can afford little beyond the basics

BY LAUREN KAORI GURLEY AND ISABELLE GIBSON

Health care, new cars and new homes feel unaffordable to most Americans, a Washington Post-ABC News-Ipsos poll shows.

Most Americans say that they can afford basic necessities like their current housing costs, groceries, utilities and gasoline. But large numbers across income lev-

els also say larger expenses and the cost of things associated with an enjoyable life — including taking a weeklong vacation — are out of reach. Overall, 53 percent of adults say they have just enough money to maintain their standard of living, nearly identical to a year ago, while roughly half, or more, say that discretionary spending on going out to dinner, vacations and new cars is unaffordable.

The findings, based on a survey of more than 2,500 Americans between Feb. 12 and 17, show why so many Americans — and politicians — cite affordability as a top concern, in spite of a booming stock market and solid consumer spending.

Inflation, which has fallen significantly below scorching post-pandemic levels, continues to

SEE AFFORDABILITY ON A5

Musk, named in Epstein files, now claims to support victims

BY FAIZ SIDDIQUI

During an explosive feud with President Donald Trump last spring, Elon Musk reached for the nuclear button. “Time to drop the really big bomb,” he wrote on X in June, “@realDonaldTrump is in the Epstein Files.”

“The truth will come out,” the Tesla CEO added. He later deleted the posts and reconciled with

Trump. In the months since, Musk has issued a steady drum beat of X posts calling for the arrest or prosecution of people linked to Jeffrey Epstein, a convicted sex offender who cultivated relationships with powerful figures in tech, finance and politics.

But when the Justice Department released what it said were millions of pages of documents in

January from its investigation of the deceased financier, Musk featured prominently in the files.

The entrepreneur had repeated email exchanges with Epstein, as did Kimbal Musk, his brother and fellow Tesla board member, the documents show. Elon Musk’s messages included inquiries about parties. Musk and Epstein also discussed arranging to meet

SEE EPSTEIN ON A6

THE REGION

Unmarked graves probed at a Virginia site where slaves once toiled. **B12**

BUSINESS

A seat at L.A. Olympics will cost fans a lot more than it used to. **B6**

ARTS & STYLE

Pamela Joyner’s love of art grew into a “call” to revive Black careers.

TRAVEL

Plane window shade up or down? You’ll make enemies either way.

\$193

SUNDAY COUPON INSERTS

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